

Build a Claude Skill That Does Your Pre-Work

From the Unscripted SEO interview with **Erika Braeger** — Manager of Organic Growth Strategy, Ten Speed · host Jeremy Rivera · "Use AI to Kill the SEO Agency Pre-Work, Not the Thinking"

OBJECTIVE

Take one analysis your team runs over and over, find the assembly work that happens before the thinking starts, and build a single AI skill that produces that starting artifact on demand. The strategist stops opening four tabs to reconstruct where an account stands and opens a finished input instead. The analysis, the narrative, the strategic decision and the client relationship all stay with the human, on purpose. Budget a couple of days to build the first one, plus one full delivery cycle running it beside the human before you trust it.

KEY STEPS

- 1. Time the pre-work before you automate anything.** For two weeks, note on each recurring deliverable where the time goes before analysis starts. You are looking for assembly, not judgement: numbers pulled out of several systems and lined up somewhere. If a task fails that test, it is not pre-work, it is the work.
- 2. Pick the most boring repeated job, not the most impressive one.** Braeger's own example is deliberately mundane: conversations scattered across systems, gathered and summarised. A monthly roll-up, a pre-call account state, a competitor refresh. Frequency beats sophistication, because a skill only pays back on repetition.
- 3. Write down what the skill will not do, first.** No recommendations, no narrative, no client-facing conclusions, no strategic decision. Put the exclusions in writing before anyone builds. This is the step teams skip and the one that decides whether the play works.
- 4. Specify the output artifact before the process.** The columns, their order, the date range, the shape of a summary, what a missing value looks like. Build backwards from that. A vague brief produces something the strategist has to reorganise, which is the same pre-work in a new hat. (*inferred*)
- 5. Name every source system and confirm access before writing a line.** Most builds stall on read permissions, seats, keys and export limits, not on capability. Braeger's watch list already runs past the analytics stack to Reddit, G2 and YouTube. If a source cannot be reached, decide up front whether the skill ships without it.
- 6. Run the skill beside the human for one full cycle.** Assemble the artifact by hand as usual, then compare. Look for what it silently dropped, not only what it got right. Close the gaps before anyone relies on it. (*inferred*)
- 7. Keep a QA pass on every run, permanently.** Not a launch checklist you retire. Assign it to the strategist who uses the output, because they are the one who notices a number that looks wrong.
- 8. Measure the returned hours by where they went.** The scoreboard is analysis, narrative, strategic decisions, helping the client execute, and growing the team. If the hours refill with more accounts per strategist, you bought throughput instead of quality.

CAUTIONARY NOTES

- **If the skill drafts the recommendation, you automated the wrong half.** Clients pay for the analysis and the narrative. A model will happily offer a conclusion at the end of a data pull.
- **A QA pass longer than the pre-work it replaced is a net loss.** Narrow the scope until the check is fast.
- **Do not build it for a job that runs twice a year.** Anything that infrequent will rot before it pays back.
- **Junior strategists lose the reps.** Someone who never assembled the data by hand has a weaker sense of when a number looks wrong. Keep new strategists on the manual pass a while. (*inferred*)
- **Some pre-work has no source you control.** Mentions across community platforms and video is Braeger's own unsolved problem. Scope around it.

TIPS FOR EFFICIENCY

- Start with the deliverable the team complains about most. The complaint is free research and adoption is already handled.
- One skill per artifact. One skill producing five outputs is five vague skills sharing a QA problem.
- Make the output identical every time. Boring and predictable is the feature.
- Ship at eighty percent and let the strategist finish by hand. A skill in use gets better; a skill in progress does not.
- The same pattern transfers to new-account onboarding, so kickoff starts at questions instead of data entry.

Source: The play is **Erika Braeger's**, Manager of Organic Growth Strategy at **Ten Speed**, a B2B SaaS content agency, on Unscripted SEO with Jeremy Rivera.

"I don't want to take away the thinking part. I want to allow the strategist to arrive at the thinking part with more ease, without burning energy, on grabbing data, organizing it out of multiple systems, organizing it in the spreadsheet."